When the Communist system began to unravel in the 1980s and when Poles within the context of their struggle against the authorities began to look back to fill the *białe plamy* [blank spots] in their history, the more inquisitive among them began to ask uncomfortable questions. How could a group that had once constituted 10% of the population disappear almost without a trace—and be completely excised from the nation's history.

In the face of serious research, the picture of Poles as "a nation without Quislings" and a society in which collaboration was restricted to miscreants slowly began to crumble. It soon became clear that the conventional, even canonical, understanding of wartime Polish society was deeply flawed and that local collaboration in the destruction of the Jewish population was far more widespread than had been believed. Wartime Polish officialdom (local administrators, police) as well as ordinary Poles had done much to facilitate the execution of the Final Solution, some of them seeing in the removal of Jews both an unimaginable opportunity for material gain as well as the removal of an alien, social element widely perceived as malevolent to Polish national and Christian values.[10] In the ongoing struggle to finally, and conclusively, deconstruct and eventually reconstruct Poland's wartime past, including the extent to which Poles were complicit in the annihilation of Polish Jewry, there inevitably emerges a bitter competition between Jewish and Polish suffering and a struggle for the moral high ground.

Not surprisingly, many elements of Polish society and some of its institutions have been loath to accept this idea and quick to accuse those who propagate it of advancing an anti-Polish agenda. The Jews, in whose name it is said they speak, are guilty of crimes against Poles—whether during the Soviet occupation of the eastern borderlands; or later in the struggle to impose Soviet control over all of Poland, which resulted in its transformation into a "people's republic."

The revelations of current research were especially shocking because under Communist rule, Poles were nearly always depicted as the prime victims of the German occupation (whether in Auschwitz, Warsaw, or elsewhere) and as gallant patriots embroiled in a ferocious struggle for freedom against the Nazi occupant. As a result, Poles never saw themselves as accessories, enablers, or beneficiaries, let alone as direct perpetrators—and Jewish dead were nearly always subsumed within Polish losses. However, with the transition to democracy, and the removal of all constraints from historical research, Polish scholars and journalists began the process of deconstruction in earnest. This sudden confrontation with the past was akin to the opening of a Pandora's box. Already in 1985, it had been observed in a pathbreaking article in an émigré journal that in wartime Polish society,

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